



CHRIBA
INSIGHTS
Vol. 4 No. 2
Sept. 7, 2026

Responding Is Not Resolving: More Replies, Same Complaints

Responding Is Not Resolving: More Replies, Same Complaints

Hwijin Baldick

Ph.D. Candidate, Purdue University

Researcher, CHRIBA

(jeon46@purdue.edu)

SooCheong (Shawn) Jang, Ph.D.

Professor, Purdue University

Director, CHRIBA

(jang12@purdue.edu)

Online review responses have become a routine part of hotel reputation management. They signal attentiveness, protect the hotel's public image, and show future travelers that guest concerns are being heard. A reply also reaches an audience far larger than the guest it addresses, since most travelers read reviews and replies without ever writing one. These are real benefits, and they explain why response rates have climbed across the industry.

Service recovery research, however, draws a distinction that reputation dashboards tend to collapse. Communicative recovery – apologizing, explaining, acknowledging – works on perceptions. Operational recovery – changing a process, a schedule, a piece of equipment, or a staffing decision – works on the failure itself. Only the second removes the cause of the complaint. Response rate measures the first and is silent on the second, which means a hotel can reach a 100% response rate while every underlying failure remains in place. Response activity is therefore an incomplete measure of service recovery: it shows that a hotel entered the conversation, not whether the same problem became less visible to the guests who came next.

This report examines that gap using 62,929 Tripadvisor reviews from 100 four- and five-star Chicago hotels, posted between January 2016 and June 2026. Review text was classified into 10 recurring complaint categories: five operational categories tied to day-to-day service delivery and five structural categories tied to physical facilities and in-room conditions. The guiding question is deliberately narrow and observable: after a hotel publicly responds to a complaint of a given type, does that same complaint type appear less often in what later guests write? Recurrence in subsequent reviews is an imperfect proxy for resolution, but it is one of the clearest signals of resolution visible to the market – and a particularly relevant outcome for the guests who come next.

Insight 1. Reply Rates Rose Thirty Points; Ratings Moved Four Hundredths

Chicago hotels have become much more active in replying to guests. That shift matters because it makes management visible in the review space. Still, visibility is not the same as improvement. The first two figures show why response activity should be read as the start of the service recovery process, not its endpoint.

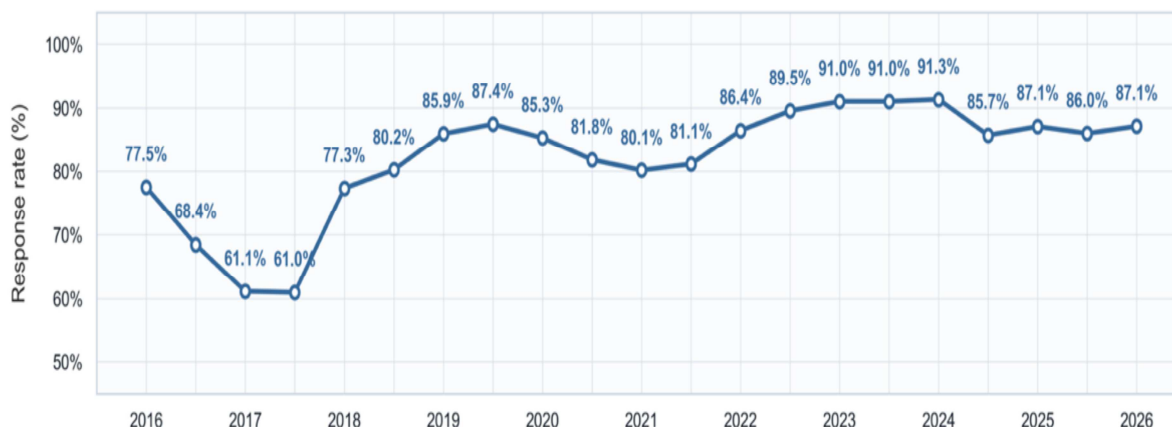


Figure 1. Owner Response Rate

Note. Each point represents six months. Response rate is the share of reviews with owner-response text.

Owner response has become a routine part of Chicago hotel review management. After falling to roughly 61% in 2017, the response rate climbed through 2018 and 2019, remained high through the pandemic period, and reached more than 91% in 2023 and the first half of 2024 before easing to about 87% by the first half of 2026 (Figure 1). Across the full ten-year window, roughly four in five reviews received some form of owner reply. Judged by presence in the public conversation, among these Chicago hotels, the response problem appears largely solved at the aggregate level: response rates are now high enough that further gains are likely to be incremental. As a result, response rate alone provides less differentiation among properties than it once did.

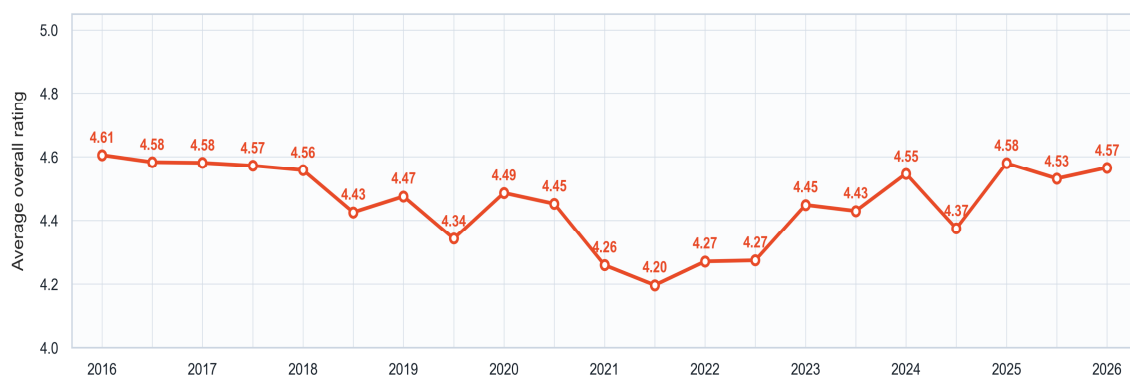


Figure 2. Average Overall Rating by Reporting Period

Note. Each point represents six months. Ratings use the 1-5 scale.

The rating pattern is much less dramatic. The average overall rating began at 4.61 and ended at 4.57, with a clear pandemic-period dip and a partial recovery afterward (Figure 2). A thirty-point rise in response activity thus coincided with a four-hundredths decline in the average rating. Two readings are possible, and neither is comfortable. If replies improve how guests evaluate a stay, the effect is too small to register against everything else that moves ratings. If replies mainly reassure the reading audience without changing the experience, this is precisely the pattern we would expect: rising visibility, static evaluation. The comparison also carries a ceiling problem worth naming – at roughly 4.6 on a 5-point scale, these hotels already sit near the top of the range, so the average rating is a blunt instrument for detecting change. This does not mean that replies have no value. It means the response-rate metric captures presence, not whether the guest experience improved in a way later reviewers could see. It is also why the remainder of this report shifts from what guests scored to what guests described

Insight 2. Guests Complain About Encounters Nearly Three Times as Often as About Buildings

The rating average, however, conceals important differences in what guests are actually complaining about. A stable overall score can hide very different kinds of dissatisfaction, and those differences matter for management. A response to a service complaint, a billing dispute, or a plumbing problem may look similar on Tripadvisor – three short paragraphs, three replies – but the work required to remove each one differs in cost, in who owns it, and in how long it takes.

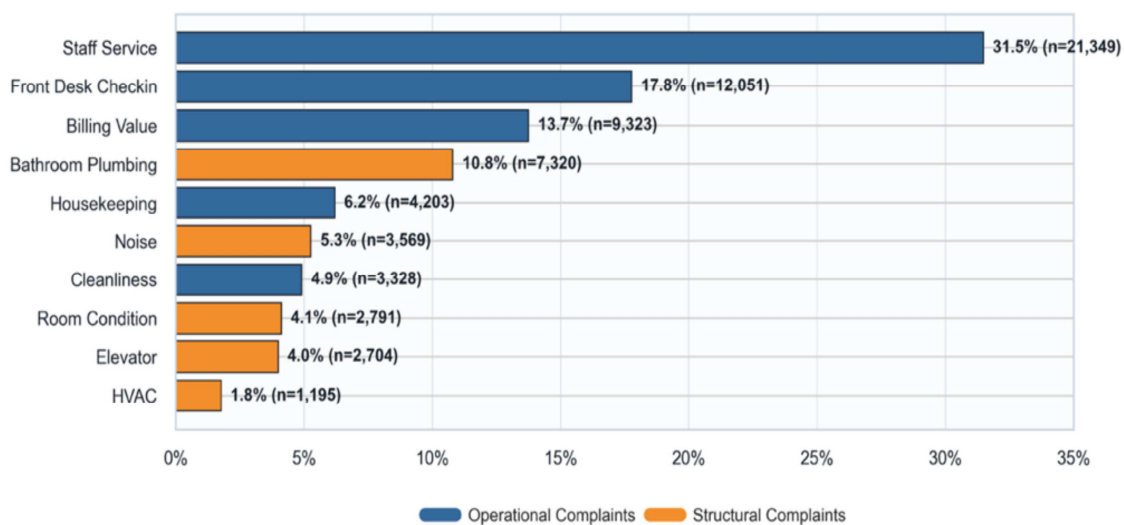


Figure 3. Complaints by Category

Note. Category-level complaint counts; one review may contribute to more than one category.

Across 67,833 category-level complaint mentions, staff service is the largest category by a wide margin, accounting for 31.5% of all mentions (21,349). Front desk and check-in complaints follow at 17.8% (12,051), while billing and value complaints rank third at 13.7% (9,323). The largest structural category, bathroom and plumbing, ranks fourth overall at 10.8% (7,320). Taken together, the five operational categories account for about 74% of complaint mentions, while the five structural categories account for 26% – a ratio of nearly three to one (Figure 3).

The pattern points to a practical management distinction. It is also consistent with what attribution research would predict. Guests read service failures as controllable and unstable: someone could have acted differently, and someone might act differently next time. That makes the failure both worth reporting and worth raising with management. Structural failures read as stable and capital-bound, and guests often discount them as a property of the building rather than a choice by the hotel.

The distribution in Figure 3 therefore reflects both what goes wrong and what guests judge worth writing about; it should not be read as a direct inventory of physical condition. Physical problems matter, especially when they recur, but most visible dissatisfaction in these reviews is tied to service encounters, communication, arrival processes, and perceived value. For managers, this means review response should not be treated as a single generic workflow. Service, check-in, and billing complaints require different follow-up paths from plumbing, elevator, HVAC, or room-condition complaints. The subratings point in the same direction: value is the only subrating below the overall rating across the full period, which aligns with billing and value being one of the largest complaint categories. Value complaints are also the least amenable to resolution by reply, because they concern the relationship between price and experience rather than a discrete, fixable failure.

Insight 3. Responses Follow Problems Rather Than End Them

The remaining figures shift from response activity to what follows it. The analysis does not claim that a reply caused later changes in guest feedback. Rather, it asks a practical management question: after a hotel publicly responds to a complaint, does the same complaint type become less common in subsequent reviews? A second caution is less obvious but shapes how the results should be read. The timing of responses is not random – hotels reply when complaints surface, so response events cluster at local peaks in a hotel's own complaint record. A series measured at its peak tends to drift back toward its own average regardless of any intervention. The design therefore leans toward finding a decline, which makes the absence of one stronger evidence than it first appears.

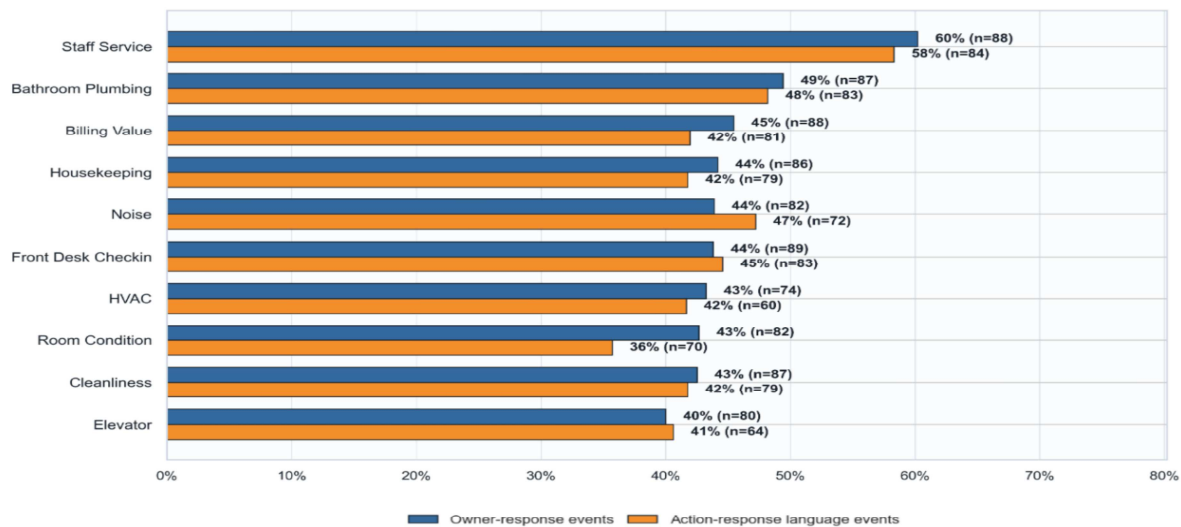


Figure 4. Post-Response Complaint Decline by Category

Note. A response event is counted when a hotel responded to a review in a specific complaint category. Action-response language means the reply said the hotel would address or had addressed the issue; it does not prove that an operational change occurred.

Staff service is the clearest exception to the broader pattern. Sixty percent of staff-service response events were followed by a lower same-category complaint rate, and 58% of staff-service responses that specifically promised action showed the same result (Figure 4). Every other category clusters in the low-to-mid 40% range, whether or not the response included action language. Across all ten categories, only 46% of owner-response events and 45% of action-language events were followed by a decline. In practical terms, a typical reply was about as likely to be followed by no improvement, or by a higher complaint rate, as by a visible decline. Measured against a coin flip, the pooled result is indistinguishable from chance.

The fourteen-point gap between staff service and the pooled average is the one clearly positive finding here, and it has a plausible mechanism. Staff behavior is among the complaint types a general manager can address relatively quickly within a single reporting period, using tools already at hand such as coaching, supervision, and scheduling. On this reading, the ceiling on post-response improvement is set less by managerial intent than by the fix horizon of the underlying failure.

Equally telling is what promised action did not do. Replies that explicitly committed the hotel to address the issue were followed by a decline no more often than ordinary acknowledgments – 45% against 46%. If promised action were reliably converted into operational change, the two series should separate. They do not. In aggregate, action language appears to function as a communicative convention rather than as a marker of work that followed.

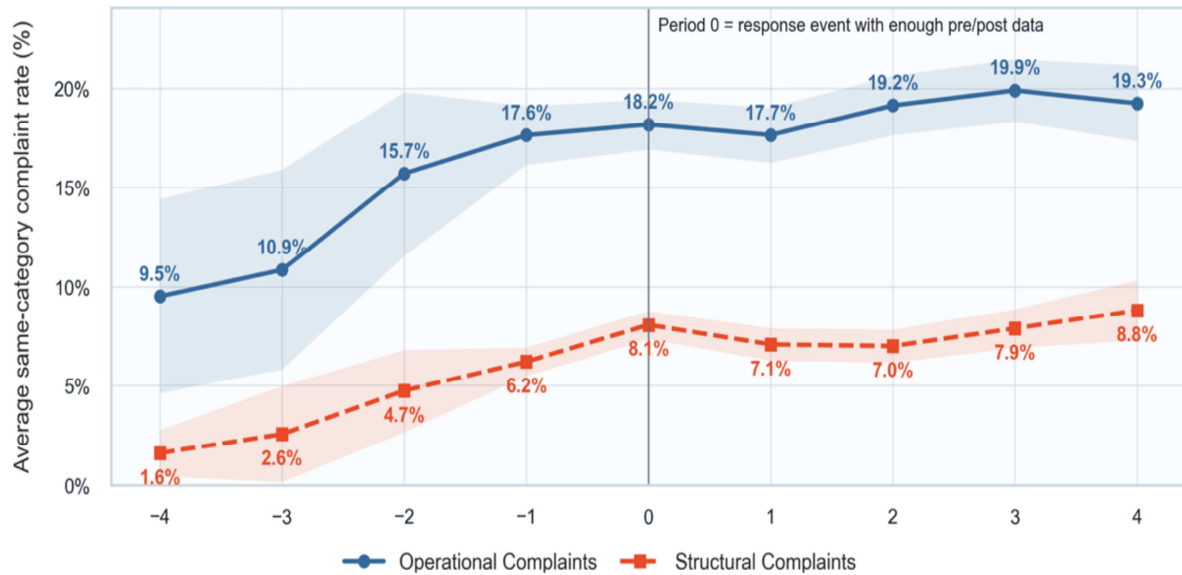


Figure 5. Complaint Rates Before and After Response Events

Note. Period 0 is the first six-month period in which a hotel had a qualifying response event for a specific complaint category, with enough pre- and post-response data for comparison.

Figure 5 places the post-response pattern in a longer time frame. Operational complaints rose sharply before the response event, increasing from 9.5% two years earlier to 18.2% in the response period, and remained elevated afterward, reaching 19.3% two years later. Structural complaints followed a similar pattern at a lower level, rising from 1.6% to 8.1% and then settling near 8% to 9%. Two features of this shape deserve attention. The pre-response climb shows that responses are reactive: they arrive after a problem has already accumulated in the public record, typically over a year or more, so the reply closes a long signal rather than opening one. The post-response plateau is the more consequential half. Because response events are identified at complaint peaks, a flat or rising series afterward means the underlying failure rate did not merely fail to improve – it resisted even the mechanical pull back toward the hotel’s own baseline. Operational complaints two years after the response event were running higher than in the response period itself. A reply may mark recognition of the issue, but it does not necessarily mean that later guests will stop reporting the same problem.

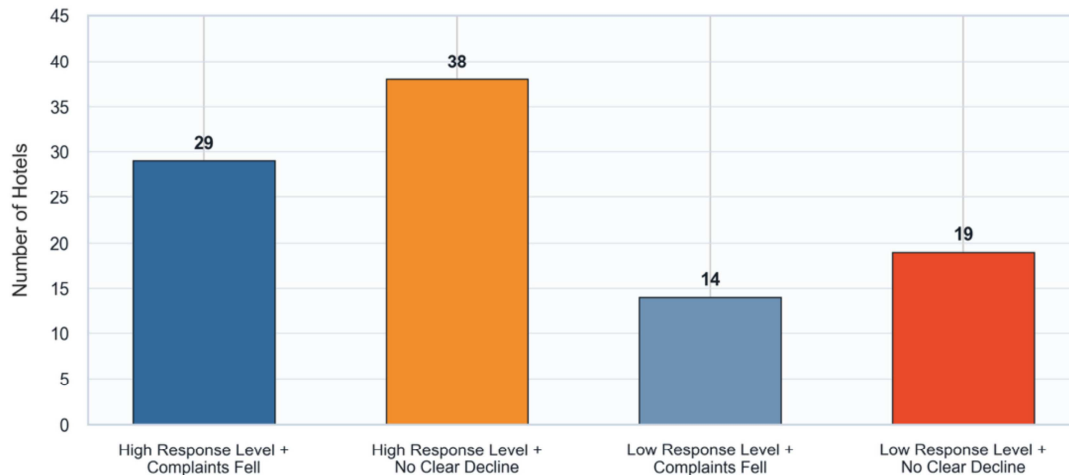


Figure 6. Response-Level Classification

Note. Bars show the number of hotels in each group. High response level means at least 70% of complaint instances had an owner response. Complaints fell means at least 50% of evaluated response events were followed by a lower same-category complaint rate. The low-response/no-clear-decline group also includes hotels with limited response-event evidence.

Source: Tripadvisor review data

The hotel-level view turns the same pattern into a management diagnostic that an individual property can apply to itself. Thirty-eight hotels responded to at least 70% of their complaints but did not show a clear decline afterward, making this the largest group in the sample (Figure 6). Another 29 hotels combined high response activity with a visible complaint decline, which is the pattern a strong review-response program should aim for. Fourteen hotels showed complaint declines despite responding less consistently, a reminder that the fix and the announcement are separable: resolution can occur without a public reply, and a reply can occur without resolution. The remaining 19 fell into the low-response/no-clear-decline group, a category that also includes hotels with limited response-event evidence. The instructive split lies inside the high-response majority. Sixty-seven of the 100 hotels replied at a high rate, but fewer than half of those (29) show evidence that the same complaints became less common afterward. High response rates are now table stakes; what differentiates properties is what happens after the reply is posted.

Conclusion and Implications

The figures point to one consistent conclusion: replying is now a standard part of hotel review management, but response activity should not be mistaken for resolution. Chicago hotels became much more active in answering reviews, while average ratings ended the period almost where they began. The most common complaints were tied to staff service, check-in, value, and communication, while structural issues accounted for a smaller but still meaningful share. Most importantly, responses were not reliably followed by lower rates of the same complaint types in later reviews. Read together, the three insights describe a

recovery system that is highly developed on its communicative side and considerably weaker on its operational side.

This should not be read as an argument against replying. A public reply can acknowledge the guest, show accountability, and shape how future travelers interpret a negative review. Staff-service complaints also show that some problems can improve after a response, especially when the issue is close to daily supervision, coaching, and scheduling. The narrower point is that a reply is not enough evidence that the problem has been fixed. Even responses that promised action were not consistently followed by stronger improvement than ordinary acknowledgments.

For hotel general managers, brand quality teams, and asset managers, four adjustments follow directly from these findings.

Measure recurrence, not just response. A high response rate shows that a hotel is present in the conversation; it does not show whether the underlying issue is becoming less frequent. A workable companion metric is a recurrence ratio: for each complaint category, the same-category complaint rate in the two periods after a response event divided by the rate in the two periods before it. A value below 1.0 indicates that the issue receded in what later guests wrote; a value at or above 1.0 indicates that it did not. Reported beside response rate, category by category, this converts a reputation statistic into an operational one. At minimum, hotels can tag each complaint by category, link the public response to an internal owner, and review whether the same category declines in the next one or two reporting periods.

Treat promised action as an opening, not a closing. Phrases such as “we will look into this” or “we have shared this with our team” should open an internal follow-up process rather than close the case. A promised action should create a record of who owns the issue, what was changed, and when the case will be checked against later reviews. The operational test is not whether the reply sounded responsive, but whether the issue was assigned, addressed, and monitored after the response. That action language performed no better than plain acknowledgment suggests this record is often missing; where it exists, it should be auditable.

Route complaints by fix horizon, not by complaint volume. Staff-service and front-desk problems often require coaching, staffing, or process changes and can usually be addressed within the current reporting period. Billing and value complaints may require clearer pricing communication, fee explanations, or service-recovery discretion and typically move on a quarterly cycle. Bathroom, HVAC, elevator, and room-condition complaints require maintenance planning, vendor coordination, and sometimes capital investment on horizons longer than the interval in which the next reviews appear. A single review-response workflow cannot resolve all of these problems equally well. For the third group in particular, candor about timing is better practice than a promise later guests can see was not kept.

Act on the second mention, not the tenth. Because complaint rates climb for a year or more before a response event, the earliest usable signal is not a single bad review but the second and third appearance of the same category at the same property. A simple category-level

trigger – an alert when a category exceeds its own twelve-month baseline – would move intervention forward into the window where it can still change what later guests experience, rather than after the pattern is already established in the public record.

These results describe what followed a response in public review data; they do not prove what caused it. Complaint categories and action language are coded from review and response text, not from internal work orders, so the analysis observes what hotels said and what guests subsequently wrote, but never what was done between the two. Three further limits bound the interpretation. Review writing is self-selected, so a change in the complaint record can reflect a change in who writes as well as a change in what happens. The sample covers one market and one segment – upscale and luxury hotels in Chicago, where business and convention demand is unusually concentrated – so the patterns may not extend to other markets or price tiers. And “decline” here is a threshold measure rather than an effect size: it records direction, not magnitude. The design is also silent on the audience effect, which is a substantial part of the case for replying – a reply may pay for itself through prospective guests who read it and book anyway, and that return would be invisible in this data. The most defensible use of the findings is therefore as a management check: a way to identify where visible response activity is not being matched by visible improvement in what guests report next.

A reply tells one guest they were heard. A resolution is what keeps the next guest from writing the same review.

About The Authors



Hwijin Baldick is a Ph.D. candidate in the White Lodging-J.W. Marriott Jr. School of Hospitality and Tourism Management at Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA. Her research focuses on consumer behavior, digital platforms, AI-mediated decision-making, and lodging experiences.



SooCheong (Shawn) Jang, Ph.D., is Professor at the White Lodging-J.W. Marriott School of Hospitality and Tourism Management in Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA. He is also the Director of CHRIBA. Dr. Jang is a Fellow of the International Academy for the Study of Tourism (The Tourism Academy) and Director of Yanolja Research. His research interests lie in hospitality strategic management, restaurant service management, and business analytics. Dr. Jang has over 250 published articles in top-tier HTM and business journals. He has been the recipient of numerous awards, such as the W. Bradford Wiley Memorial Best Research Paper of the Year Award in 2009, the Martin Oppermann Memorial Award for the JTTM Best Article of the Year in 2014, the Michael D. Olsen Research Achievement Award in 2015, and the Founder's Award during the 29th Annual Graduate Education and Graduate Student Research Conference in Hospitality and Tourism in 2024, the Founder's Award during APTA (Asia Pacific Tourism Association) 2025. Moreover, he has been recognized as the top-ranked author in HTM academia during the past decades by the Journal of Hospitality and Tourism Research (2011), and the International Journal of Hospitality Management (2018 and 2019). Dr. Jang is often invited as a speaker for academic research or interdisciplinary research at various universities and international conferences.

Disclaimer

The *CHRIBA Insights*, produced by the Center for Hospitality and Retail Industries Business Analytics (hereafter the [CHRIBA](#)) at the White Lodging-J.W. Marriott, Jr. School of Hospitality and Tourism Management at Purdue University, is intended solely for the purpose of sharing knowledge with academics and practitioners. The information and findings presented in this report are not intended to be construed as professional advice, and readers are encouraged to seek appropriate professional guidance for their specific needs. The [CHRIBA Insights](#) is protected by copyright laws and requires express written permission for reproduction, distribution, or modification. Proper citation and attribution are necessary when referencing the report. Unauthorized usage may result in legal action. The [CHRIBA Insights](#) is provided "as is" without any warranty of accuracy, completeness, or reliability. The [CHRIBA](#) is not liable for any loss or damage arising from the use of the report. References to third-party sources in the *CHRIBA Insights* are for informational purposes only and do not imply endorsement or responsibility by the CHRIBA.

Date of publication: September 7, 2026

Email: chriba.official@gmail.com

Website: <https://www.chriba-purdue.com/>